community was hybrid: that of the Pattunulkarar was called Patnuli, involving a mix of Gujarati, Marathi, Kannada, Telugu and Tamil. Like in Baroda, the weavers in south India were also known to ‘vote with their feet’ to less oppressive tax regimes. While these migrations were extensive, there was another kind of migration occurring in medieval India, within and between frontiers, and those migrants did not necessarily weave silk. On the contrary, they were sometimes traded in return for woven silk.

Slaves

Many people in India derive their conception of slavery from Hollywood movies depicting slaves in American history. Slavery was a defining issue in American politics, and its abolition in most places of the world in the 19th century was a major moral victory for humankind. Between the 16th and 19th centuries, an estimated 12 million slaves were forcibly transported from Africa to the Americas across the Atlantic, the majority in fact going to Brazil and the Caribbean, and not North America.[68] The trans-Atlantic slave trade was enormous in scale and one of the largest forced migrations of all time, but it was not the first time the world had experienced slavery, nor was slavery unique to that part of the world.

Slavery existed in ancient India and is well-documented in the *Arthashastra* through the use of the words *dasa* (slave), *dasabhava* (the state of being a slave), *dasakalpa* (rules related to slavery) and *dasatva* (concept of slavery), representing the most unfree kinds of labour.[69] This was distinct from bonded labour where workers mortgaged themselves to their masters. There was even a four-fold categorization of slaves: those who were inherited, born in the house, bought, or procured by other means such as capture or gift. The punishment for slaves breaking the laws were harsh and those caught stealing male or female slaves would have both their feet cut off. There were possibilities of manumission, or obtaining freedom, on receiving redemption money, or in the specific case of a slave giving birth to a child of her master in which case both the slave and her child